

Why Should We Care?

In this essay, I reconstruct and defend Christine Korsgaard's procedural realism. I argue that procedural realism can survive David Enoch's Schmagency objection and can concede the existence of schmagents while retaining its universality and categoricity.

I. Summary

Korsgaard's Kantian constructivism holds that normative obligation arises from our autonomy and agency. Korsgaard's mission is to explain universal normative authority and how there can be facts about what we are obligated to do. Because humans are self-conscious and self-reflective, we reflect on our desires and ask whether we have reason to act on them. This reflective process requires practical identities, "a description under which you find your life worth living" (Korsgaard, 101), which generate our obligations.

Korsgaard argues that we obtain reasons for our choices through reflection in light of our practical identities. Reflectively endorsing an action constitutes reflective success, so moral terms "good" and "right" refer to actions and maxims that receive reflective endorsement, and "ought" refers to obligations arising from our practical identities. Although some practical identities are contingent, Korsgaard argues that our shared humanity provides a universal moral identity. Obligations stem from the practical identities we value, so moral judgments are intrinsically motivating and abandoning all practical identities would cause us to lose meaning and direction in our lives.

Korsgaard's constructivism is attitude dependent, where humanity is the source of value and moral facts depend upon human attitude endorsement. While Kantian maxims have intrinsic normativity¹ independent of our attitudes, they become moral laws only when willed by rational agents. Thus, values are "objective" in the sense that the maxims they reference may hold intrinsic goodness or badness, but they do not become values until we endorse them, so they are subjectively dependent on our practical identities. Since humanity is a universal identity, though, the values we endorse as humans are attitude dependent but "objective" in their universality given shared humanity.

II. Clarifications

Korsgaard's incorporation of Kantian maxims in her constructivist theory can make her view appear realist. However, she rejects stance-independent moral facts. "Procedural realism" holds that moral facts are constructed by reflective lawmaking, as opposed to "substantive realism," where moral facts exist stance-independently.

In addition, despite being an attitude dependent theory, Kantian constructivism accounts for categoricity and universality of our moral identity by citing Kant's Moral Law. The Moral Law is the law of the Kingdom of Ends that directs us to only act upon maxims that all rational beings would agree to act on together in a

¹ Korsgaard breaks down the meaning of intrinsic normativity as having value that is dependent on its internal structure: a good maxim must be good for its own sake (final) in virtue of its intrinsic structure (Korsgaard, 111).

cooperative system. Because rational action requires valuing our humanity, she argues, we must view ourselves as members of the Kingdom of End.

Finally, Kantian constructivism differs from Humean constructivism in the source of normative authority. Kantian constructivism famously derives moral obligation from what is constitutive of rational agency, which Korsgaard argues is the aim of self-constitution through endorsing consistent Kantian maxims. In contrast, Humean constructivism embraces relativism by deriving moral obligation from contingent attitudes and reasons that serve our desires.

III. Comparison

A. Reductive Naturalism

Procedural realism resembles Railton's reductive naturalism because both posit a reflective procedure that guides action. For Railton, the agent A strives to adopt the interests of their A+ idealized self, through an iterative, reflective process that adjusts A's subjective interests to align with their objectified subjective interests. For Korsgaard, the reflective process guides us to take actions that align with the obligations of our practical identities. However, Railton's agent A is *discovering* the A+'s objectified subjective interests empirically, whereas Korsgaard's agent is *creating* the values through reflective endorsement. Additionally, both views connect moral rightness to shared human interests: Railton defines "moral rightness" as social rationality: X is morally right if X would be approved of if all objective interests of the relevant individuals were considered and weighed against each other; Korsgaard views moral rightness as the obligation that stems from our practical identity as a member of the Kingdom of Ends. However, Railton's naturalistic objective interests are not intrinsically motivating, whereas Korsgaard claims moral obligations are intrinsically motivating because they arise from practical identities we value.

B. Emotivism

Both emotivism and procedural realism reject mind-independent moral facts and ground normativity in human subjectivity rather than non-natural entities. However, emotivism treats moral judgments as non-cognitive expressions of emotion, whereas procedural realism is cognitivist: moral statements could be true or false based on the existence of intrinsically good or bad maxims and the reflective procedure that causes us to endorse certain maxims over others.

IV. Positive Argument

1. Realistic Reflective Process

Procedural realism aligns with the phenomenology of the first-person deliberation without requiring any mysterious metaphysical entities. If stance-independent moral facts existed, then practical reasoning would require perceiving or detecting these moral facts, which does not fully match the reflective reasoning process. When we deliberate, we are weighing competing obligations that arise from what we care about, which is closer to constructivism than realism. In addition, Korsgaard rightly observes that after we reflectively decide upon an action, we either feel a sense of integrity, being true to our identity, or a feeling of betraying ourselves because our

action either aligns or conflicts with our practical identities, rather than because we have correctly or incorrectly identified an external fact.

2. Motivational Internalism²

Procedural realism gives an account for motivational internalism that other views such as realism lack. A robust realist struggles with motivational internalism because a naturalist would simply not accept motivational internalism and assert that moral facts carry no more internal motivation than natural facts, and a non-naturalist would have to assign some special motivational quality to a stance-independent moral fact, which would be subject to Mackie's queerness objection.

In procedural realism, because reasons stem from the identities we hold, if we want to continue identifying as a given practical identity, we feel motivated by this practical identity to take actions that would make ourselves more aligned with said identity. Thus, the reason and the motivation to follow this reason stem from the same source. In particular, our moral identity as autonomous humans compels us all to recognize the obligations we hold towards other humans, so anyone who identifies as an autonomous human must feel internally motivated to act accordingly.

3. Explains Moral Disagreement

Procedural realism explains both moral disagreement and agreement across time periods and cultures. The procedural realist explains disagreement with the fact that people have different practical identities that they've adopted from different personal experiences, so their reflective process will yield different results. In contrast, the realist might have difficulty explaining moral disagreement because they must explain how we would know who is right, and why we are bad at detecting moral facts, given that disagreement exists despite the supposed existence of moral facts. However, there exists a lot of moral convergence across societies and cultures as well, which Korsgaard attributes to our humanity, a universal practical identity that provides us with universal obligations.

V. Objections

A. Enoch's Agency, Schmagency Argument

Enoch's argument aims to counter theories that derive normative truths from facts about the nature of agency. Korsgaard's constructivism is one such theory: she argues that normative reasons and obligations stem from caring about our identity as autonomous humans, or agents. Enoch's argument has two questions: 1. Do we have a reason to be agents? and 2. Why should we care about being agents? Constructivists frequently answer the first question with the inevitability of agency, which elides the necessity of a reason to be an agent. However,

² Motivational internalism is a contentiously debated property of normative statements; I believe motivational internalism is more appealing than externalism, due to the way we treat our moral beliefs. If someone believes "Killing is wrong" but feels no motivation against killing, we would think he is either confused, irrational, or being disingenuous about his beliefs. In light of the word limit, I do not delve into the arguments for or against motivation internalism, but I acknowledge that this may be a controversial view.

Enoch counters this point with the second question, arguing that psychological and metaphysical inevitability does not equate normativity.

Enoch uses the example of playing chess to illustrate the challenge. He posits a situation where the agent is trapped in front of a chess board. The agent may be forced to play chess, but they do not have to internalize the aims of the game. Analogously, Enoch says, we may not be able to opt out of agency. However, we can refuse the normative grip that agency has over our actions – we can be schmagents instead, people who operate just like agents in every way, except denying the aim of self-constitution.

B. Robust Metaethical Realism

Enoch proposes an alternative to Korsgaard's constructivism: Robust Metaethical Realism. Enoch argues that the source of normativity must stem from non-natural, irreducibly normative truths, rather than our agency and autonomy. He believes that the answer to the schmagency question, "Why should we care to be agents?" must be some independent normative truth. His argument for robust normative truths relies on defining indispensability. Enoch defines two types of indispensability: intrinsic and instrumental. Intrinsic indispensability describes a project that we cannot opt out of, and a belief is instrumentally indispensable to a project if we cannot engage in such a project without having this belief. Enoch argues that deliberation is instrumentally indispensable, and belief in attitude independent, non-natural moral facts is instrumentally indispensable for the project of deliberating, thus justifying our belief in such independent facts. To prove the instrumental indispensability of belief in objective moral facts, Enoch cites the observation that deliberation is a process that feels like searching for a correct answer, or discovering what decision to make, which inherently assumes reasons must exist independently of our decision.

VI. Response to Objections

I posit that universality and categoricity of procedural realism does not require that agents are normatively compelled to always care about their agency. Instead, procedural realism can remain universal and categorical as long as it provides normative reasons that apply to reflective agents independent of their attitudes.

Both Korsgaard and Enoch acknowledge that we are inescapably agents; we cannot avoid rational deliberation and reflective reasoning. Where Korsgaard and Enoch diverge is that Korsgaard thinks the reason to care about our agency lies in the fact that our agency has the constitutive aim of self-constitution; insofar as we care about the practical identities that we comprise, we must care about our agency. Enoch does not accept the last step in this chain of reasoning; he argues, the psychological and metaphysical inevitability of agency does not give rise to any normative authority making us care – so what if we take "schmactions" that lack the aim of self-constitution?

I argue that Korsgaard could concede the existence of schmagents without relinquishing the rest of her argument. By nature of asking the question, "Why must we care about being agents?", we are deliberating. By Enoch's definition, deliberation is the process of searching for the "correct" answer, and this deliberative

structure commits us to instrumentally indispensable stance-independent normative truths. However, even granting that deliberation is a discovery process, it does not follow that it is stance-independent normative truths that are instrumentally indispensable rather than normative laws constructed through the reflective structure. Thus, the intrinsic indispensability of deliberation does not immediately lead to the existence of stance-independent normative truths.

Enoch argues that stance-independent normative truths are necessary for the universality component of Korsgaard's argument though, because otherwise an agent could just operate as a schmagent. I argue that an analogous argument threatens robust realism. Let us consider the sensible knave. The sensible knave perceives that a stance-independent normative fact tells him he must care about his agency. He asks, "But why?" and proceeds not to care about this stance-independent normative fact; only after he accepts the rightness of this normative fact will he recognize its authority over himself. There will always be bad actors; however, both realists and constructivists identify standards that apply to rational actors while acknowledging that some agents could reject or fail to act accordingly. Thus, if the existence of the sensible knave doesn't undermine the universality of realism, the schmagent shouldn't undermine procedural realism's either.

Furthermore, I argue that procedural realism does present a categorical reason for why we *should* care and therefore why most rational agents *do* care. Certainly, we could choose to be a schmagent and reject the aim of self-constitution. Possessing the aim of self-constitution is to iteratively create and transform our sense of self via reflecting and acting on obligations that form and reinforce our practical identities. Rejecting the aim of self-constitution is to reject the goal of creating a coherent, unified self. Thus, being a schmagent has dire implications for our identity – it is choosing to abandon the obligations of our practical identities. If we do not reinforce our practical identities with our actions, we lose these practical identities, which by definition means losing the ability to act with reasons. Enoch asserts that as rational deliberators, we search for reasons to act; this is the basis of his deliberative indispensability argument. Thus, if he argues attitude-dependence for Korsgaard's assertion that we should care about our agency because we need reason to act, then he is undermining his own deliberative argument.

Ultimately, Enoch's chess analogy does not generalize well. We can choose not to care about playing chess because playing chess is a choice external to our agency. However, in the case of agency, the choice to play the game is the game itself; by choosing to play or not play, we are already playing. And as to why we should care, I argue that we need not be necessitated to care; just as in realism, the normative facts do not necessitate us to care. However, we do need a categorical reason to care, which Korsgaard provides and Enoch cannot deny if he wishes to remain consistent with his structure of deliberation.

VII. A Final Thought

We have addressed Enoch's Schmagency argument and how procedural realism can still retain its universality. I wish to conclude by suggesting an alternative view that integrates procedural realism into realism. Korsgaard references Kantian maxims that possess intrinsic normativity. However, she claims that these are not moral facts

because we have not yet willed them into laws. I argue that these Kantian maxims could operate as the stance-independent normative facts of robust realism. They perhaps differ in that a robust realist's stance-independent truths contains more normative authority than the Kantian maxims. However, our endorsement still plays a role in robust realism in order to make these normative truths into laws that dictate our own actions. Thus, to say that procedural realism is *creating* normative truths is correct, but in some ways it is also *discovering* maxims that are fit to be "truths." If we wanted to adopt robust realist leanings, we could argue that Kantian maxims are stance-independent normative truths, but they don't become normatively authoritative laws that govern our own actions until we will them to be. Thus, robust realism still requires the reflective process proposed by procedural realism to fully capture the normative authority that moral truths hold over us.

Sources

Enoch, David. "Agency, shmagency: Why normativity won't come from what is constitutive of action." *The Philosophical Review* 115.2 (2006): 169-198.

Korsgaard, Christine M. *The sources of normativity*. Cambridge University Press, 1996.